Your Mother's Butt

By Alan Ball

INTRODUCTION

Without fail, just about anything that goes wrong in a child's life is the mother's fault. What a good idea it would be to have child psychiatry a regular part of annual well child doctor's visits. After the vaccinations and the eye-chart test, the child could lie down on a chaise and spill for the doc all the ills he feels mom has inflicted on him. "My mom won't leave the hall light on at night and the noises outside my window scare me." We could take care of the problem right there at age 5 and avoid having the same conversation with a therapist 30 years later and deciding that mom's hall light failings are to blame for the adult child's foibles. In this selection our client seeks psychiatric attention for his increasing dissatisfaction with life and as is typical . . . . His therapist attempts to trace his many idiosyncrasies directly to what she affectionately calls . . . Your Mother's Butt by Alan Ball.

CLIENT: My life is, like, so mundane. The days come, the days go. I keep waiting, waiting, waiting, but for what? I go to work, I eat, I work out. I watch television. I'm not really depressed. Well, yeah, I guess I am depressed. I'm lonely. I'm easily irritated. But it's not the kind of overwhelming depression that feels like it's ripping me apart. It's more of a . . . blandness, an overall numbness. . . like every fiber of my being has been sucked dry of any coherent reason to exist. (Pause.) Nothing matters.

PSYCHOLOGIST: Nothing?

CLIENT: No. (Pause. The CLIENT cries.) I have- (It is too painful for him to say; takes a moment, then tries again.) I have this sweater. .

PSYCHOLOGIST: A sweater?

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CLIENT: It's really nice. It's this old sweater, I think it belonged to my brother. It's just this black V-neck sweater, wool, but it's faded and soft and it fits me really well, it accentuates my shoulders, but, like, in a subtle way, and when I wear it, I feel really sexy.

PSYCHOLOGIST: You have every right to find joy in a sweater.

CLIENT: I do, that's the weird part, it's like the only thing in my life I get excited about. Sometimes I put it on just to vvalk around in it, and then sometimes I forget that I've done laundry and I go to pick out something to wear, and there it is, all clean and soft and faded just a little bit more, all folded up, and it's, like, primal, like, maybe even religious. (Pause.)

PSYCHOLOGIST: How are you feeling?

CLIENT: How do you think I'm feeling? The only significant relationship in my life is with a piece of clothing? At best, that's tremendously shallow, and at worst, it's sociopathic. I mean, if I was somebody else and I knew me, I would say look, get a life.

PSYCHOLOGIST: I think perhaps you're being a bit hard on yourself.

CLIENT: You're right. God, I am so messed up. I've got to do something about this, I can't be this messed up anymore. What can I do? Tell me what to do. You're the expert.

PSYCHOLOGIST: Well, first, I think we need to take a look at why you are so hard on yourself. (Pause.)

CLIENT: (Sighs.) Okay. (Long pause.)

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PSYCHOLOGIST: How are you feeling?

CLIENT: Excited.

PSYCHOLOGIST: Excited?

CLIENT: Yeah. I'm thinking about this pair of shoes I saw yesterday.

PSYCHOLOGIST: Shoes?

CLIENT: Yeah. I've been looking for the perfect pair of black shoes for. . . well, probably for my whole life. You know, a pair of oxfords, just plain, nice leather, not too clunky, but not too Wall Street, either. The kind of shoes you can wear with a suit and look really hip, but you can also wear with blue jeans and look really. . . intelligent.

PSYCHOLOGIST: Intelligent.

CLIENT: But also approachable. And politically correct. With a sense of humor.

PSYCHOLOGIST: Shoes seem to communicate quite a lot for you.

CLIENT: Oh, yeah. Definitely. I think there's two ways to learn a lot about somebody in a short amount of time. One is their refrigerator-not only what they stick on the front of it, but what's in it, too-and the other is their shoes.

PSYCHOLOGIST: (A hunch.) What's in your refrigerator?

CLIENT: Well, nothing right now.

PSYCHOLOGIST: Ah.

CLIENT: These shoes are the greatest shoes-I think.

PSYCHOLOGIST: Let's stay with the image of the empty refrigerator for a moment.

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CLIENT: Why?

PSYCHOLOGIST: I have an idea it might be significant.

CLIENT: Okay.

PSYCHOLOGIST: (Taking time, setting mood.) A cold, white, empty box. . . possibly a source of nourishment, but also a potential death trap. (Pause.)

CLIENT: Cool. (Pause.)

PSYCHOLOGIST: Perhaps we should return to the shoes.

CLIENT: Okay. (Pause.) I don't know. They might be the right ones, they might not. They're really expensive. I don't want to spend that much money and have them not be the perfect shoes! (Suddenly angry.) God, why does everything always have to be so hard?

CLIENT: Weird. I just remembered. . .oh, I had this weird dream.

PSYCHOLOGIST: Tell me about it.

CLIENT: I dreamed. . . I dreamed I was in this. . . house, it wasn't my house, but I lived there. And I was in this big room, and I was in this bathtub. This old-fashioned bathtub on pedestals. And I'm wearing clothes. This olive drab cardigan, just over a T-shirt, and these flax-colored, I guess, linen shorts. And then I hear these voices in the hall and in comes my mother. Only she's a younger version of herself, and she's wearing these 1960s hip-huggers, and she has Mary Tyler Moore hair that she's tied a bandanna around, and I think oh, she's trying to be hip, and it's really sort of sad for a moment. . . then she

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gets in the bathtub with me, only she won't look at me, and then she bends over and. . . she just sticks her butt in my face.

PSYCHOLOGIST: (Scribbling furiously.) This is really good.

CLIENT: And I'm thinking. . . okay. This is kind of weird. . . this is really. . . it's really not quite right. . . it's really. . .

PSYCHOLOGIST: Inappropriate?

CLIENT: It's more than that. . . Oh, God, what is it?

PSYCHOLOGIST: Visualize the dream.You're in the water. . . Is the water warm or cold?

CLIENT: Warm. But not hot.

PSYCHOLOGIST: And she comes in.

CLIENT: Yeah, and she's walking this swingy, hippy kind of walk, and I think oh, God, my mother. I'm so embarrassed.

PSYCHOLOGIST: And she gets in the tub. . .

CLIENT: You can tell she thinks she's really groovy.

PSYCHOLOGIST: Now she's in the water with you. . .

CLIENT: Yeah. And she is wearing the most hideous Barbie, like, flower power outfit and macramé belt.

PSYCHOLOGIST: She's turning around. She's bending . . .

CLIENT: Oh, wait a minute! I just realized something. Oh, wow. (Pause.)

PSYCHOLOGIST: Yes?

CLIENT: It makes such perfect sense, doesn't it.

PSYCHOLOGIST: What does?

CLIENT: I get my bad belt luck from her. It's heredity. (Long pause.)

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PSYCHOLOGIST: (Just the slightest bit if tightness.) How are you feeling?

CLIENT: I feel great! If it's hereditary, then I don't have to feel guilty for it. I have no control over it, so it's not my fault. Right?

PSYCHOLOGIST: Well, not exactly, no. One of the underlying assumptions that the therapeutic process is based upon is that you do have control over your life.

CLIENT: No ,thanks. I don't want that kind of responsibility. (Pause.)

PSYCHOLOGIST: I'd like to get back to your mother's butt.

CLIENT: Please. Be my guest.

PSYCHOLOGIST: It's such a strong image, with so many potential implications. It could open many doors. So I'd like to try something a little . . . unorthodox.

CLIENT: Oh, no. You're not going to stick your butt in my face, are you?

PSYCHOLOGIST: No, no. I just want you to close your eyes, and relax. Feel the warm water in the tub. Now try to picture your mother's butt.

CLIENT: Okay.

PSYCHOLOGIST: Do you see it?

CLIENT: Plain as day.

PSYCHOLOGIST: Now speak to it.

CLIENT: I'm sorry?

PSYCHOLOGIST: Speak to your mother's butt.

CLIENT: Oh, right.

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PSYCHOLOGIST: Think of it as separate from your mother. As an entity of its own. If you could communicate with it, what would you say?

CLIENT: Get out of my face.

PSYCHOLOGIST: Perhaps it would be helpful if you gave it a name.

CLIENT: What do you mean?

PSYCHOLOGIST: If it had a name, what would it be?

CLIENT: You mean like a person's name?

PSYCHOLOGIST: Possibly.

CLIENT: Like. . . Debbie?

PSYCHOLOGIST: Perhaps.

CLIENT: This is really weird.

PSYCHOLOGIST: Just try speaking to it by name.

CLIENT: Get out of my face, Debbie. Excuse me, Debbie, can you get out of my face? Thank you. Yo, Debbie. Get the heck out of my face.

PSYCHOLOGIST: Maybe you'd like to yell at it.

CLIENT: Sure, why not. (Yells.) Debbie! Get the hell out of my face, you witch! And take that hideous macramé belt with you!

PSYCHOLOGIST: Now become the butt.

CLIENT: What?

PSYCHOLOGIST: If you were the butt, what would you say in response?

CLIENT: Uhm, I'm Debbie the butt, and you better shut up. Stop telling me what to do. This is a free country and I can be wherever I want. If you don't like me being in your face, then you leave.

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PSYCHOLOGIST: Now respond as yourself.

CLIENT: You stupid butt. I was here first.

PSYCHOLOGIST: Keep going.

CLIENT: Oh yeah, well. . .

PSYCHOLOGIST: Keep going.

CLIENT: I'm confused. Am I me or am I the butt?

PSYCHOLOGIST: Keep going!

CLIENT: But

PSYCHOLOGIST: Don't turn away from this! We're right on the verge of something!

CLIENT: Um

PSYCHOLOGIST: Don't hold back! Tell that butt how you are feeling!

CLIENT: (Loses it.) God! Shut up! Get out of my face, get out of my bathtub, get out of my life, you butt! I hate you, I hate you, I hate your guts! (He sobs uncontrollably. Long pause.)

PSYCHOLOGIST: How are you feeling now?

CLIENT: I feel like the biggest jerk in the universe. I'm never telling you another dream again. But. . . oh, wow. Wow. This is intense.

PSYCHOLOGIST: What?

CLIENT: Have you ever been hit with, like, this realization, it's, like, something you always knew, but it's the first time you've ever really seen it so clearly? Oh this is so weird, it's like deja vu.

PSYCHOLOGIST: What? (The CLIENT sits up and looks at her.)

CLIENT: (With great resolve.) I don't care how expensive they are, I'm buying those shoes! (Blackout.)

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